

What is drama ?



- ❖ Drama: one of the oldest form of art.
- ❖ Both a **literary art** and **performing art**.
- ❖ The Western dramatic tradition has its origins in **ancient Greece**
- ❖ Greek tragedy originated in the dithyramb (酒神赞歌) to pay tribute to Dionysus (酒神) at the **Dionysia** (酒神节).
- ❖ “Tragedy, then, is an imitation of an **action** that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude; ...

(Aristotle, *Poetics*)

The Elements and Structure of Drama

Aristotle categorized drama into six elements in his *Poetics* 《诗学》 in order of importance as he viewed them:

- **Plot**
- **Character**
- **Thought**
- **Diction**
- **Spectacle / Visual effect**
- **Music / choral odes**

Plot: the soul of tragedy

- ❖ Plot is the way the story is told. (plot cf. story)
- ❖ Story: a narrative of events arranged in their time sequence.
- ❖ Plot: a narrative of events, with the emphasis falling on **causality**. The time-sequence is preserved, but the sense of causality overshadows it.
 - ❖ E. M. Forster, *Aspects of the Novel* (1927).

Structure of the Plot

- ❖ beginning → middle → end; or
- ❖ exposition → complication → denouement
- ❖ exposition → complication → reversal → resolution

Exposition

❖ **Exposition** (戏剧呈现):

- ✧ sets the action in time and place (situation) and makes us acquainted with the characters;
- ✧ initiates the **conflict** to be developed (**point of attack** 交锋点), and it may introduce **foreshadowing** to hint at the resolution.
- ✧ Must be done clearly and quickly.

❖ **Foreshadowing**: clues carefully inserted in early parts of the play which

- ✧ make the subsequent action credible.
- ✧ build suspense and create tension (suspense cf. surprise)
- ✧ reveal character, and aid in the development of complications.

Complication (深度推进和冲突复杂化)

- ◆ Develops the **conflict** initiated by the exposition, providing the conflict with its depth and breadth
- ◆ **Terms concerning plot**
 - ◆ **point of attack** 交锋点: that moment in the play at which the sense of balance is disturbed; or when an inciting force triggers the course of action
 - ◆ **rising action** 动作上行: accumulation of incidents and development of character, carrying the conflict forward to the play's high plot, its **climax**.
 - ◆ **climax (turning point, reversal)** 高潮
 - ◆ **anticlimax** 突降, 反高潮 any high point in the story after climax.
 - ◆ **falling action** 动作下行
 - ◆ **Subplot/double plot** 次要情节/双重情节

Denouement (结局)

Ideally the denouement arises **logically** from the exposition and complication. Following the climax everything heads downward in **falling action**. Things fall into place, and the play heads toward the conclusion. Then it's all over.

Dramatic terms related to **Character**

❖ **Types of characters:**

↪ **Protagonist** 主角

↪ **Antagonist** 反角

↪ **Foil** 陪衬人物



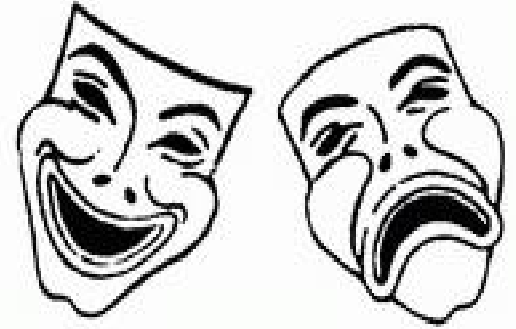
- ❖ **Character:** any person appearing in a drama or narrative
- ❖ **Protagonist**---the main character in a drama. This character is usually the most interesting and sympathetic and is the person involved in the conflict driving the plot.
- ❖ **Antagonist**---a character or force in conflict with the protagonist. The antagonist is often another character but may also be an intangible force such as nature or society.
- ❖ **Foil**---a character who, through difference or similarity, brings out a particular aspect of another character. Laertes, reacting to the death of his father, acts as a foil for Hamlet.

❖ **Two types of character** (E.M. Foster in *Aspect of the Novel*):

❖ **Round or three dimensional characters** (圓形人物) : well-developed character, usually neither wholly good nor wholly evil, but wholly human; the most convincing and rich characters.

❖ **Flat character or Stock character** (类型化人物/扁平人物)--- underdeveloped or stereotypical character whose behavior, qualities, or beliefs conforms to familiar dramatic conventions.

Characterization



- ❖ Characters may be portrayed in 4 ways
 1. by **appearance**
 2. by **speech**
 3. by **action**
 4. by **what other say about him, and the way in which they react to him.**

Diction

- ❖ (Compared with novel) The language of drama must be **dynamic** (in the sense to advance the action), purposefully selected to convey the background information as well as characters' thoughts and feelings.
 - ❖ **clear** and **suited for oral expression**: be immediately understood by the listener.
 - ❖ **interesting** despite the need for **simplicity** and **economy**.
 - ❖ **appropriate** for the character and the situation.

Thought

- ❖ **Thought:** the reasoning aspect of drama.
- ❖ Thought concerns a play's theme which summarizes the moral and indicates the symbolic meaning of the play as a whole.

Spectacle

- ❖ Spectacle: all of the visual aspects of production—scenery, lightening, costume, make-up, and the movement of the actor.
- ❖ The current accepted attitude is that the visual aspects of theatrical production is just to provide the psychological and physical environment and create the atmosphere for the play.

Music



- ❖ **Music:** all of the auditory aspect of a play.
- ❖ **Function:** to enhance the mood of the play
- ❖ **Including:**
 - ❖ 1. the expressiveness of sound (and silence)
 - ❖ The silence in Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*
 - ❖ The sound of African drums throughout Eugene O'Neill's *Emperor Jones* (It not only greatly intensifies the sense of fear but almost assumes the role of an invisible character or force throughout the play).
 - ❖ 2. the tonal pattern of the spoken word

Genres of Drama

- ❖ **Tragedy** 悲剧
- ❖ **Comedy** 喜剧
- ❖ **Tragicomedy** 悲喜剧
- ❖ **Melodrama** 情节剧
- ❖ **Farce** 闹剧
- ❖ **Problem play** 问题剧
- ❖ **Feminist theatre**

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Definition of Tragedy

- ❖ “Tragedy, then, is an imitation of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude; ... with incidents arousing pity and fear, wherewith to accomplish its *katharsis* of such emotions. . . . Every Tragedy, therefore, must have six parts, which parts determine its quality—namely, Plot, Characters, Diction, Thought, Spectacle, Melody.”
- ❖ 悲剧 “是对一个严肃、完整、有一定长度的动作的摹仿；目的在于引起怜悯和恐惧，并导致这些情感的**净化**”
--- 亚里士多德，《诗学》

■ Tragic protagonists:

- (before mid-18th century) not a god, but a human of a certain noble stature, a high-born individual. E.g. Oedipus in *Oedipus the King* (Sophocles)
- (In modern concept) commonplace heroes, an element of human greatness beyond the ordinary. E.g. Willy Loman in *Death of a Salesman* (Arthur Miller)

■ Tragic protagonists' personalities develop out of moral choices under extreme pressure.

■ **Tragic flaw:** a combination of character traits that results in misjudgment and finally leads to the tragic heroes' destruction. Whether you call it pride, arrogance, vanity or whatever, within the human psyche must rest the seeds of doom. The protagonist is doomed, and we watch in awe as he moves towards that doom.

- Tragedy is an assertion of the greatness of man. It shows man's ability to rise to the height of human dignity in the face of an opposing force which he himself knows will finally destroy him.
- Tears that may be shed at the final catastrophe are not tears of sadness, but of compassion.
- By the end, when tranquility has been restored, the audience has gone through a kind of spiritual purgation, in the realization of how great the human being can be upon occasion.

Tragedy is positive and optimistic in its view of the heights the human being can reach.

Comedy

- ❖ Comedy: broadly applied to a **light, humorous play** that ends happily.
- ❖ Comedy might show how amusing, how foolish, how illogical, people are. In contrast to tragedy which demonstrate the height of greatness human being can attain, comedy shows the man's **follies, foibles and vices**.

For all its painting of man's failings, comedy is usually affirmative, leaving us pleased and gratified.

Tragicomedy 悲喜剧 (正剧)

- ❖ Traditional tragicomedies: combines certain elements of both tragedy and comedy. The plot tends to be serious, leading to a terrible catastrophe, until an **unexpected turn** in events leads to a reversal of circumstance, and the story ends happily (a serious action with a happy ending) e.g. *The Tempest* (Shakespeare)
- ❖ Modern tragicomedies: neither tragic nor comic e.g. *Waiting for Godot* (Samuel Beckett)
- ❖ Purpose: to describe the dual nature of reality, where both modes can coexist, perhaps simultaneously.
- ❖ Characteristics: often employs a romantic, fast-moving plot dealing with love, jealousy, disguises treachery, intrigue and surprise, all moving toward a **melodramatic resolution**.

Problem Play 社会问题剧

- ❖ Drama of social criticism developed in the 19th century that discusses social, economic, or political issues in realistic manner (part of the wider movement of Realism).
- ❖ Characteristic: it presents the problematic issues through debates btw. characters on the stage who represent conflicting points of view
- ❖ Purpose: to expose social ills; to stimulate thoughts and discussions
- ❖ Representative playwrights:
 - ↪ Alexandre Dumas, fils (French): *La Dame aux camélias*
 - ↪ Henrik Ibsen (Norwegian): *A Doll's House; Ghosts; An Enemy of the People*
 - ↪ George Bernard Shaw (Irish): *the Widowers' Houses; Mrs. Warren's Profession; Man and Superman; Major Barbara; Pygmalion*

Susan Glaspell (1876-1948)

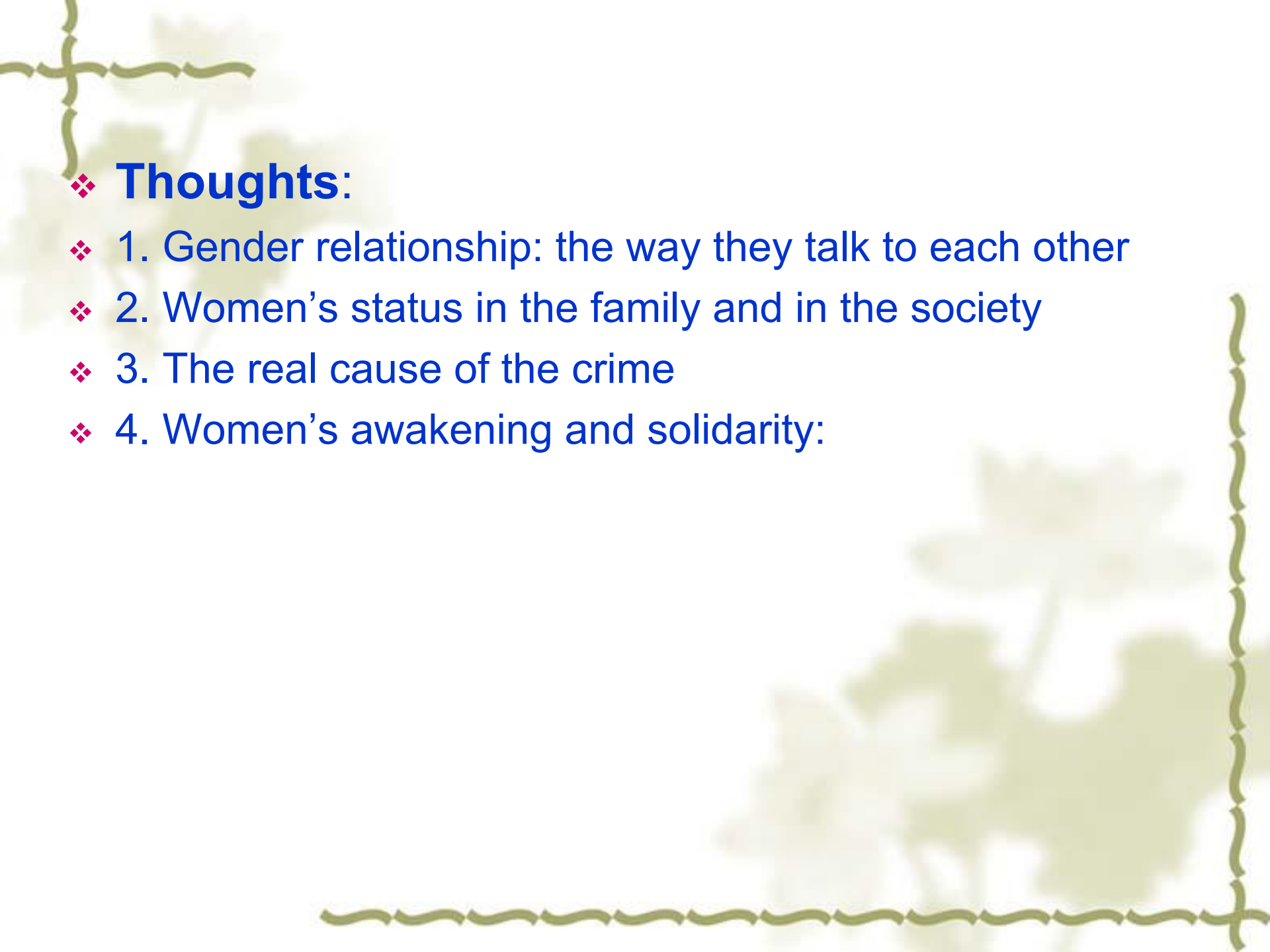
- ❖ American playwright, novelist, journalist and actress
- ❖ Glaspell is today recognized as a pioneering feminist writer and America's first important modern female playwright.
- ❖ Her one-act play *Trifles* (1916) is frequently cited as one of the greatest works of American theatre, and was adapted in 1917 as the short story “A Jury of her Peers” 《同命人审案》.
- ❖ Based on the murder trial Glaspell had covered as a young reporter in Des Moines a decade ago, written during the times of the ‘Suffragette Movement’ the first wave of Feminist movement in the early 20th century.

The Trifles by Susan Glaspell (1881-1948)

- ❖ The story: (p. 246) a legal investigation of a murder of the farm's owner, John Wright, who is strangled to death in sleep.
- ❖ The theme: a murder mystery that explores gender relationships, and power struggles between the two sexes.
- ❖ The setting: a bleak, untidy kitchen in an abandoned rural farmhouse, with a cold winter wind blowing outside.

The Six Elements

- ❖ **Spectacle** : the cold, gloomy kitchen of the Wrights.
- ❖ **Music**: the blowing winter wind
- ❖ **Plot**: a crime investigation
 - ↪ Exposition/ Complication/ Denouement:
- ❖ **Characters**:
 - ↪ Mrs. Minnie Wright (Minnie Foster), the crime suspect
 - ↪ Mr. John Wright
 - ↪ Henry Peters, the sheriff
 - ↪ George Henderson, the attorney
 - ↪ Lewis Hale, a neighbor
 - ↪ Mrs. Peters
 - ↪ Mrs. Hale
- ❖ **Diction**



❖ **Thoughts:**

- ❖ 1. Gender relationship: the way they talk to each other
- ❖ 2. Women's status in the family and in the society
- ❖ 3. The real cause of the crime
- ❖ 4. Women's awakening and solidarity:

Two modes of perspective and behavior

Men

- ❖ 1. **the house** as scene of a crime; tramp around the farmhouse searching for clue, and attempt to look methodical; professional
- ❖ 2. **Investigation:** methodical, conduct the investigation by the book through the eyes of legal investigators, following the preset plan of the search: interview the key witness, asking for only facts.

Women

- ❖ 1. **the house** as a home; move through the kitchen, talking and reflecting; emotional and sensitive
- ❖ 2. **Investigation:** formless, based on bits of trivial evidence; talking, reflecting and reconstructing the accused woman's life: memories of Minnie; memories of their own lives which are similar to hers in many ways, and speculation about Minnie's feelings and responses.

The symbols in the play

- ❖ The cold, gloomy kitchen: loveless marriage/family life,
- ❖ the died-out fire: died-out love or hope,
- ❖ the broken jars: broken heart
- ❖ the bird: women in marriage,
- ❖ the cage: marriage
- ❖ The knot (to tie the knot): 1) a stitching technique; 2) the knot of rope on Mr. Wright's neck; 3) the knot of marriage that ties Minnie; 4) the bond of solidarity